MUSIC DNA

NOVEMBER 8, 2026 / LIVE PRODUCTION REVIEW

THE CRITIC EXPERIENCE RESET

Great engine. Wrong stage. MusicDNA has learned to respect the evidence, but the fun got lost in the presentation.

A live six-round walkthrough, honest critique, visual interaction directions, and a bounded implementation brief for Lovable and Codex.

3 OPENERS **6 MATCHUPS** **1 PUSHBACK**

Observed in production. Proposed mockups are illustrative; no diagnostic policy change is authorized.

1 / LIVE WALKTHROUGH

The session, not a simulation

Three opening favorites, six real choices, a disagreement, and a post-reveal challenge were completed at musicdna.fm.

THE OPENING

Talking Heads / Once in a Lifetime + Joy Division / Love Will Tear Us Apart + Childish Gambino / Redbone

Early replies: "Interesting place to start." / "Two very different rooms. Interesting."

	CHOSEN	OVER
01	Rebellion (Lies)	Dog Days Are Over
02	Maps	Heat Waves
03	Banquet	Kids
04	Breezeblocks	De Selby (Part 2)
05	Mr. Brightside	Use Somebody
06	Kids	Maps

THE POST-REVEAL FAILURE

After the listener explained choosing Maps for Karen O's vulnerable vocal, the critic said it "couldn't ground" the reply. The new version appended the correction rather than holding a satisfying conversation.

2 / WHAT LEAKS ENERGY

Five experience failures

The issue is not absent intelligence. It is misdirected attention, voice, and pacing.

P0

No instant reward

First opener responses are generic. Three typed favorites feel like work before the game starts.

P0

No active stage

History, notes, theory, and songs scroll together. The current choice is not visually sovereign.

P0

Evidence copy as entertainment

"Choice noted" recurs. Counts and disclaimers are elevated to giant primary headlines.

P1

Pushback feels swallowed

"Not quite" steers a pairing but mainly acknowledges via toast; chat fallback ignores the actual correction.

P1

No earned finale

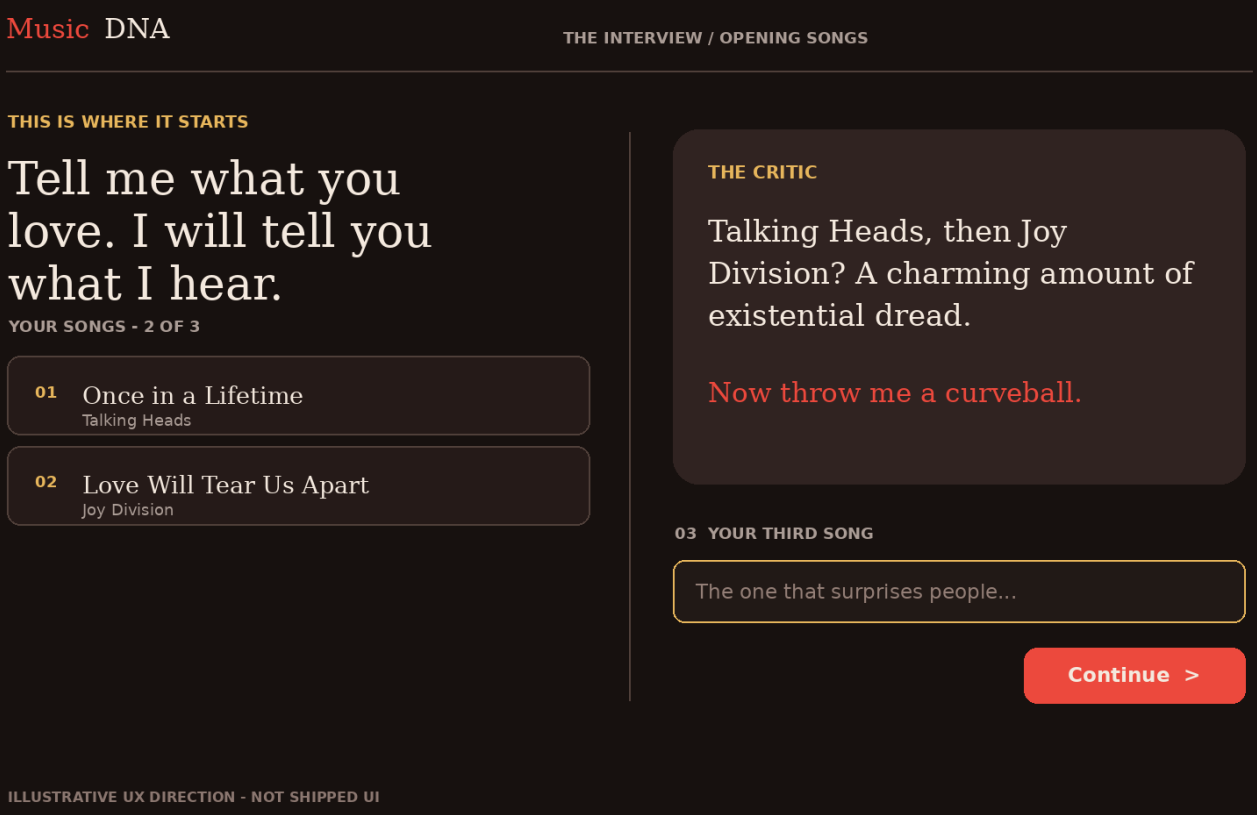
The reveal repeats the same "danger over release" read, with little new surprise or reason to share.

Research-quality warning: four of six observed matchups offered only 2000s songs. The finale then treated the selected-era concentration as a possible listener confound, although the game imposed much of it.

3 / VISUAL CONCEPT A

Opening: earn the next song

Three favorites, one at a time. The critic notices the song without pretending to know the listener yet.



ILLUSTRATIVE UX DIRECTION - NOT SHIPPED UI

+ Specific commentary after each song, not "Interesting."

+ Input and next prompt remain in one active scene.

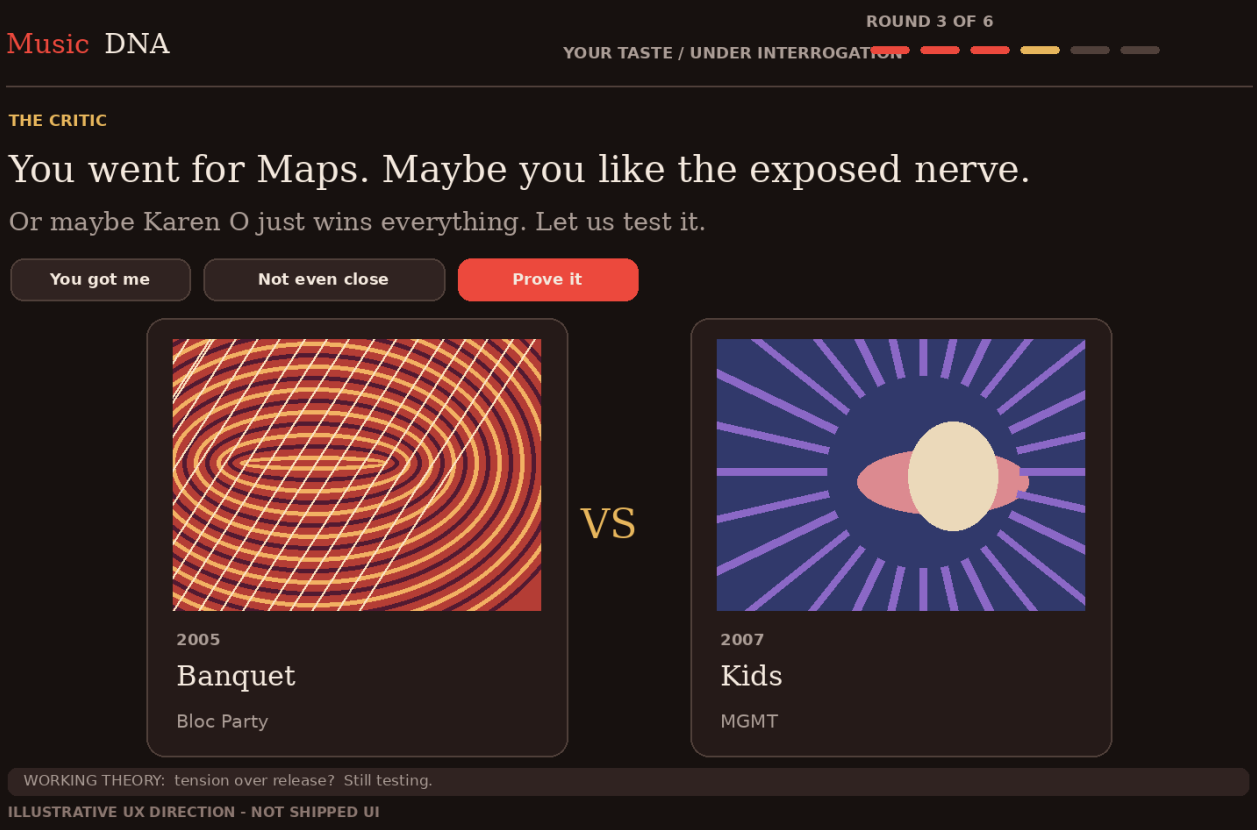
+ Opener songs stay self-report priors, never diagnostic votes.

Feel: the listener walked into a lively record-store conversation, not a form.

4 / VISUAL CONCEPT B

Matchup: let the music lead

The song cards, short critic line, challenge chips, and six-step progress make the next move impossible to miss.



+ Visual choice cards, immediate winner/loser feedback.

+ One short theory; history and evidence are secondary.

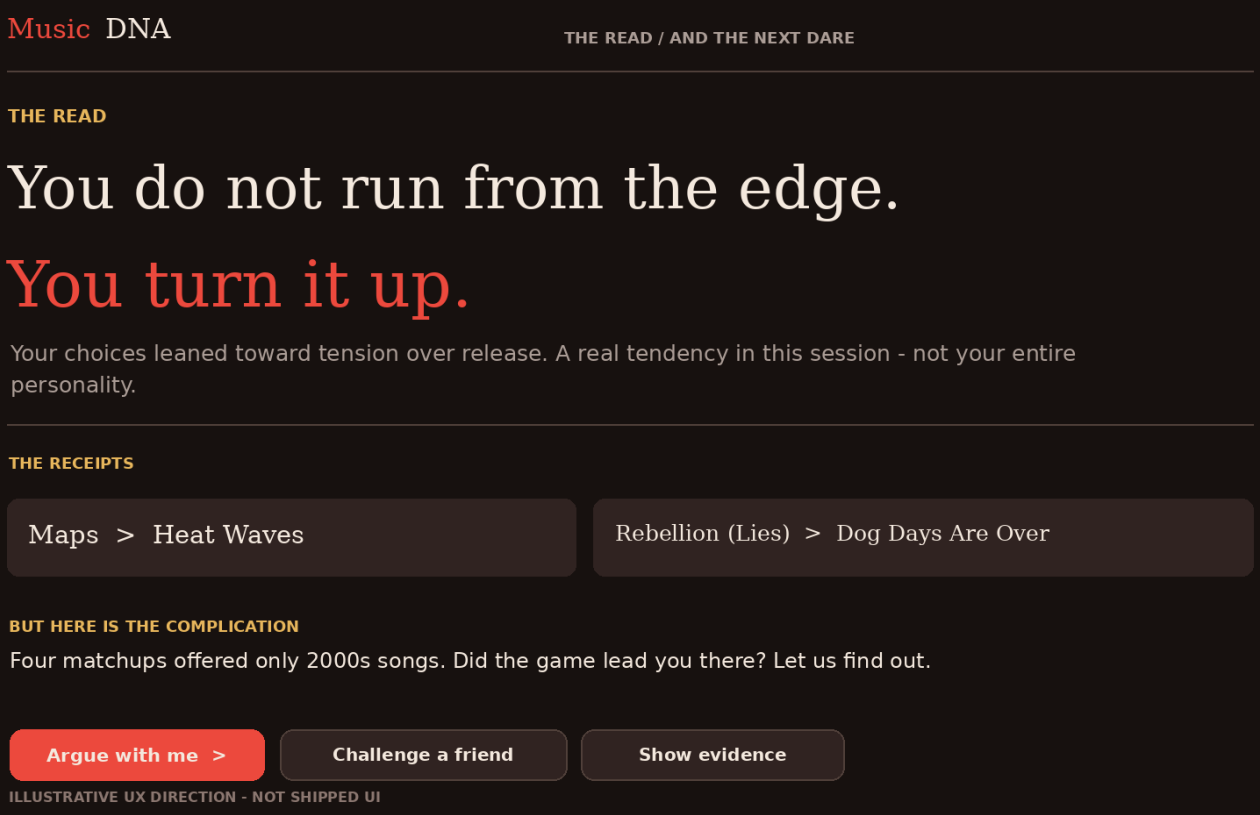
+ A visible answer to every reaction, especially "Not quite."

Feel: quick, witty, personal, and slightly confrontational. The pairing is the game.

5 / VISUAL CONCEPT C

Reveal: give me a line worth sharing

The result should add synthesis, show receipts, admit a real loose end, and invite a new round of conversation.



+ One headline; two grounded receipts; one unresolved tension.

+ "Argue with me" stays in the same visual world.

+ Share is opt-in. Detailed counts remain available on demand.

Feel: surprise first, evidence second, a new dare third. No bureaucratic summary.

6 / HOW TO BUILD

Separate truth from voice

The engine decides what can be said. The critic decides how to make saying it entertaining.

AUTHORITATIVE EVIDENCE

Immutable choice ledger > validated claims > supporting choice IDs > uncertainty/revision status

BOUNDED EXPRESSION

Short critic line > human question > explicit next action. Never invent songs, claims, or support.

THE CURRENT SOURCE OF THE CLINICAL TONE

musicdna.functions.ts
Fixed "Choice noted" acknowledgment per vote

engine/claim-language.ts
Counts and caveats assembled into primary copy

components/musicdna/reading-result.tsx
Full synthesis displayed as a heading

hooks/use-interview.ts
Reaction effect mainly shown in a transient toast

routes/me.tsx
Entire old reading before the actual conversation

TONE: A MUSIC CRITIC, NOT A RESEARCH BOT

"Maps over Heat Waves. Okay, that is an interesting nerve to touch. I am not calling it yet."

"You might prefer the exposed nerve to the easy exit. Or maybe Karen O wins everything. Want to test that?"

Do not change: canonical claim policy, server-owned completion, idempotent choices, frozen results, explicit sharing, chat self-report separation, or REST/Flutter compatibility.

7 / DO THIS NEXT

One focused UX sprint

No feature explosion. Approve the three key screens and a six-round storyboard before integrating changes.

A **Approve interaction storyboard**

Desktop + 390px mobile, including a specific six-round story and one real pushback.

B **Build an active-stage shell**

Current pair + short critic + progress; history behind a drawer. Preserve server mutations.

C **Add bounded expression**

Structured evidence IDs and confidence govern the text; the editorial layer handles voice.

D **Make the challenge playable**

Visible reaction consequences, specific chat fallback, compact result above conversation.

E **Audit pairing diversity**

Separate offered-era concentration from selected-era concentration; validate catalog tests.

ACCEPTANCE GATES

1. Active choice + progress obvious on mobile. 2. No repeated hero paragraph. 3. Reaction visibly changes the conversation. 4. Finale offers fresh, warranted synthesis. 5. Correction is acknowledged without becoming a vote. 6. Three-minute session, keyboard/reduced-motion accessible. 7. No ontology leakage or invented evidence.

North star: "Holy shit, how did it know that about me?" Not a playlist generator. A mirror for your taste.